and had to be doused with pitchers of water and then relighted a couple of hours before we arrived.

We sat down beside the blazing hearth, just the two of us and our interpreters, and I told Gorbachev that I thought he and I were in a unique situation at a unique time: “Here you and I are, two men in a room, probably the only two men in the world who could bring about World War III. But by the same token, we may be the only two men in the world who could perhaps bring about peace in the world.”

Borrowing a quotation, I continued: “Mr. General Secretary, ‘we don’t mistrust each other because we are armed; we are armed because we mistrust each other.’ It’s fine that the two of us and our people are talking about arms reductions, but isn’t it also important that you and I should be talking about how we could reduce the mistrust between us?”

In the preceding months I’d thought many times about this first meeting with Gorbachev. Nothing was more important to mankind than assuring its survival and the survival of our planet. Yet for forty years nuclear weapons had kept the world under a shadow of terror. Our dealings with the Soviets—and theirs with us—had been based on a policy known as “mutual assured destruction”—the “MAD” policy, and madness it was. It was the craziest thing I ever heard of: Simply put, it called for each side to keep enough nuclear weapons at the ready to obliterate the other, so that if one attacked, the second had enough bombs left to annihilate its adversary in a matter of minutes. We were a button push away from oblivion.

No one could win a nuclear war—and as I had told Gorbachev in one of my letters to him, one must never be fought.

When I had arrived in the White House in 1981, the fiber of American military muscle was so atrophied that our ability to respond effectively to a Soviet attack was very